Q+A

SPEAKING FROM THE HEART

As SWARA BHASKER gears up for the September 16 release of her film *Jahaan Chaar Yaar*, she says that even though Bollywood is in flux, it is too early to write off the industry

Q. We have seen friendship and road trip films before. What sets *Jahaan Chaar Yaar* apart?
What's special about it is that for the first time, Bollywood has front-and-centred people that are dismissed by the elite snobbish crowd as '*behenjis*'. We are taking that derogatory term and flipping it by showing how cool, badass, sassy and full of life they are. I play the doormat, the meekest character of the group.

Q. Was it tough to get into her psyche?
I may not be that person but I very much get it. There is a way in which marriage swallows Indian women completely. My family is full of over-earnest, devoted women who even with careers have given their all to their families. Slipping into the role was seamless, but what was nice was discovering layers to Shivangi.

Q. You have never shied away from speaking your mind. Do you feel you have borne the brunt of it on the work front?
I am told, 'People are terrified of casting you because you're too controversial'. There is an atmosphere of fear in the industry and [streaming] platforms. In that context, Vinod Bachchan [the film's producer] is a very brave man. I do continue to get work from independent producers and directors.

Q. With the failure of *Laal Singh Chaddha* and *Raksha Bandhan*, there's this sense that nobody knows what works in Bollywood any more. Do you concur?
I don't fully agree. This is a moment of disruption because cinemas were shut and OTT platforms filled the space, changing consumption patterns. Even then, we've given a hit film—*Gangubai Kathiawadi*, *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2*, *Jug Jugg Jeeyo*—every two months. The four language industries in the South have given four hits in the past nine months. Their films are also struggling.

-with Suhani Singh

BANDEEP SINGH